

Group Co-Leadership Self-Evaluation Paper Assignment

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I have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

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Leading groups is something I have done since I was newly married, 19 years old, and helping reinvigorate a local church. Those groups were not therapy groups nor were they aptly led. I felt confident going into this intensive week of 512 but I learned much from Dr. Ford and Dr. Vuncannon as I observed and helped lead, teach, and supervise the course.

Reflection on Skills

If you led a group session, what skills did you excel at, and which skills do you need to develop further? Or, if you did a demonstration, what skill did you demonstrate?

In leading the group, I excelled at reflections and linking. I appreciate Dr. Ford's use of repetition to teach students what the most basic and important parts of group leadership are. As she explained the skills necessary, I too found the admonition to stick to reflection on the members' content, emotions, and meaning important. I was able to do so in an effective manner. I also found linking the members' emotions and content together to be quite effective. However, being too focused on the person sharing or my process commentary, I failed to adequately sense the other members' reactions and bring them into the process. This is something I will discuss below as important to the group co-leader. Bringing the other members into the discussion is something I excel at as the co-leader (pulling from experience) but not as the leader. I can improve on this by training myself to look around the circle (or square of squares) and pay attention to the faces and non-verbal communication of the group. According to my instructor evaluation, I need to improve at the skill of paraphrasing, use of silence, and group exercises. The instructor did mention the brevity of the experience as one reason these skills were lacking. However, I do agree that, typically, these are skills that I am not proficient at.

Reflection on Co-Leadership

What did you learn about the co-leadership relationship? Or, if you led a demonstration, what did you learn about teaching group counseling?

As I was leading the group, Dr. Vuncannon was sending me messages via Teams. I found this at times distracting and at times encouraging and helpful. I did learn that the insight and eyes and ears of a second person are invaluable when dealing with so many points of reaction. It is nearly impossible for one person to pick up on every communication from the group. Acting as a second set of eyes and ears, my co-leader was able to cue me into the observations he was making. One unique and interesting part of virtual meetings is that the co-leader can give this observation to the leader in a way that doesn't interrupt the flow of what the leader is doing. Although there is nothing wrong with a co-leader chiming in with her observations, the idea that a more experienced leader can help a new leader find their footing and build confidence in this manner is intriguing. I believe that all this communication should be brought into the group even if it is just the overall communication that it will happen. Nonetheless, it is a new way of pairing up to give the best group experience possible.

Reflection on Self

What did you learn about yourself as a group leader? Or, if you led a demonstration, what did you learn about yourself as a group leader trainer?

Self-reflection is always helpful in solidifying an experience for me. Emotionally I sensed heightened anxiety when leading this group. The anxiety was due to the fear of being inadequate or the professor being overly critical of my work. I also sensed joy. The joy was a reflection of the many personalities and the proficiency they were showing as the week went on. I believe this shows my tendency to please people in public situations where others can affect

me. It also shows my desire to affect others positively. I want clients and students to have a good impression of me. In the group, this reflects my social microcosm. I am as affected in a therapy group (even an academic therapy group) as I am at the office Christmas party. For this not to interfere with my leadership ability, I will need to focus on the client's goals. If the client is a supervisee under my direction, I will need to stay focused on the learning objective so the course. If I am constantly concerned about the supervisee's or student's ordeal, then I will miss opportunities to facilitate growth. I can also remember Dr Vuncannon's comment that I have very good group skills and given time I could master the ability to lead groups well.

I am convinced this experience has made me a better group leader. Although there were limits to the extent of the learning, it will stay with me a long time and I will continue to sense how it has positively impacted me.